

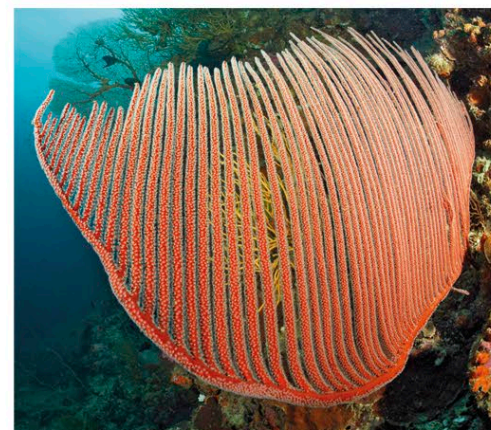


Andaman Sea Reefs

Some of the largest continuous areas of coral reefs in south Asia, with an enormous variety of fish, corals, and other invertebrates



Situated in a northeastern corner of the Indian Ocean, the Andaman Sea bathes the coasts and coastal islands of Thailand and Myanmar on its eastern side and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands on its western side. Most of the coral reefs here are fringing reefs, and altogether they cover an area of some 2,000 square miles (5,000 square km). The reefs contain a wide diversity of marine life, with over 500 fish species and 200 coral species recorded. The reefs and nearby islands are also important feeding and breeding grounds for endangered sea turtles.



△ COMB CORAL

This soft coral is known for its distinctive comblike shape. It has long, unbranched stems and can grow up to 5 ft (1.5 m) wide.

Nusa Tenggara

A chain of coral islands in southern Indonesia, fringed by reefs that contain a high diversity of marine life



Stretching eastward from Bali, Nusa Tenggara includes several large islands such as Lombok, Sumbawa, and Flores, as well as 500 smaller islands. Many of the fringing reefs around these islands have barely been explored, but as a whole the area is known to include around 500 species of reef-building corals. Common animals seen on the reefs include eagle rays, humphead parrotfish, and various species of nudibranch (sea slug) and octopus.



△ DENSE HABITAT

Just beneath the surface, a mass of stony corals covers a fringing reef a few hundred feet off the coast of Flores in eastern Nusa Tenggara.